

Our topic today is the believer in immaterial souls view that
we are (either wholly or in part) immaterial things.

You may recall that we came up with two believer in
immaterial souls answers to the identity question:

A large blue circle with a white drop shadow, containing the text "Simple dualism: I am an immaterial soul" in white. The text is centered and arranged in four lines.

**Simple
dualism: I am
an immaterial
soul**

A solid blue circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is centered and reads: "Fusion dualism: I am a combination of a soul and a body".

Fusion
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**Soul
survival:**

X is me just in
case X is the
same immaterial
soul as me

Fusion survival:

X is me just in case X
has the same immaterial
soul as me and is the
same material thing as
me

For right now we're going to set aside the question of which of these views is better.

Instead, we're going to ask a more fundamental question: is there any good reason to believe in the existence of immaterial souls?

Most of us don't believe in fairies, there being no good evidence for their existence. Why should souls be any different?

We're going to look at two different arguments for the
existence of souls.

The first begins with the idea that souls are required to
explain the existence of consciousness.

Properties related to conscious experience include the property of feeling an itch or a pain, or the sensation of seeing red or hearing a loud noise. These properties are sometimes called **phenomenal properties**.

This seems to be a statement of the general principle that if human beings are wholly physical things, then all of their properties must be physical properties.

“If a human person is a physical thing, any change whatever in a human person must be a purely physical change. If, for example, Tim becomes elated because of some news contained in a letter he has just received, this change in Tim, his becoming elated, must be the very same thing as some purely physical change.”

What do materialist theories of persons imply about phenomenal properties? Here is what Peter van Inwagen says:

First, let's consider a paradigmatically physical property, like the property of being water. What makes this a physical property?

We'll now look at an argument that phenomenal properties are **not** physical properties — which, given the above, would show that we are not wholly physical things.

Let's pretend for simplicity that protons, neutrons, and electrons are the most fundamental physical particles. Suppose now that we start with these basic building blocks and construct some molecules which contain two hydrogen atoms and one oxygen atom. Suppose now that we combine a quantity of these molecules in some container.

Would we have to do anything else to fill the container with water?

It seems clear that we would not. Once you arrange basic particles into H_2O molecules, you have made water. It would be **impossible** to have a quantity of H_2O without having water.

Another way of putting this is that once you have fixed all of the facts about the fundamental particles, you have also fixed all of the facts about water.

Let's call the facts about the fundamental physical particles the **basic physical facts**. Then the idea is that the basic physical facts **necessitate** the water facts.

This seems like a pretty plausible definition of a physical property: a property is physical just in case the basic physical facts necessitate all of the facts about which things have the property.

Consider some more complex properties, like the property of being a cell, or being made of wood, or being a pumpkin. Are these all physical properties, in this sense?

It seems clear that they are. It is pretty difficult to imagine something which is a molecule for molecule duplicate of a piece of wood which was not itself a piece of wood.

Indeed, at this point it might seem hard to see how **any** property could fail to be a physical property. It might seem that **all** of the facts about the universe are necessitated by the basic physical facts about the universe.

This thought suggests a certain sort of naturalistic, scientific view of reality. On this sort of view, we, and the world we inhabit, are fundamentally physical things. Ultimately everything about us, and the world we inhabit, can be explained in terms of the basic physical elements of which we are all composed.

Water (once thought to be a primitive element) is just a certain combination of hydrogen and oxygen; heat (once thought to be an invisible fluid) is just molecular motion; life (once thought to be a primitive force) is just a complex series of biochemical reactions. Just so, phenomenal properties (which after all are studied by neuroscientists) will just turn out to be properties of the brain and nervous system.

This brings us to the central mystery of consciousness: phenomenal properties do not fit as neatly into this naturalistic worldview as one might expect.

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